

Bawdy Copy

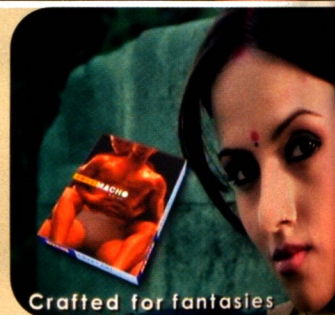
To build an instant connect with target audiences, advertisers and brands are indulging in lewd commercials for a range of products, from communication services to toothbrushes

■ By Malini Bhupta

Sex sells. And the creatively-challenged advertising fraternity is liberally using the three-letter word to sell everything from underwear to e-mail service. In a bid to get a brand noticed really quick, advertising agencies are taking a rather bawdy route to nirvana. Faced with a cluttered television environment, where 200 odd channels air thousands of commercials everyday, creatives are increasingly becoming obscene, vulgar and over the top. So it isn't really surprising to see an advertisement for designer jeans, where the model is showing off her underwear rather than the pair of jeans. The campaign was for print media, which sought to promote jeans by Rocky S, but the advertisement was discontinued as the core product was nowhere in sight. Rather than making the product the centre of the communication, advertisements today seek to shock and titillate through sexual innuendos and indecent representation of the female form. Even though the usage of both kinds of creatives go against the code of Self Regulation in Advertising, such commercials are increasingly becoming par for the course.

There is so much of pressure on both the brands and their agencies to deliver that the need to bring in the sexual element is immense. Explains Rocky S: "My advertisements are all about the feel of my fashion. It doesn't need to have the products on display. As long as the aura and the feel come across, my message is conveyed." Currently, the talk of the town are two underwear commercials—Amul Macho and Lux Hosiery. Underwear brands today believe that qualities like comfort and quality are a given, so the

brief (no pun intended) to the creative agency is personify intangible qualities of the brand like virility and machismo. A similar brief had been given to Pushpinder Singh of Saints and Warriors by Sandeep Sekhsaria, the promoter of Amul Macho. Says Sekhsaria: "The intent was to portray the brand as a personification of machismo. Therefore, the commercial



Crafted for fantasies

has a woman fantasising about her husband while washing his underwear. The hue and cry is because it's a woman who is fantasising and not a man." In their bid to get noticed, small-time brands are trying to cater to fan the latent sexual fantasies and desires of people. The dividing line is very thin between naughty and vulgar, believes Singh. While the Amul Macho ad passed the Advertising Standards Council of India



REDIFFMAIL

The commercial played on 'Raju's size'. It passed the ASCI scanner although it was clearly lewd. It was rejected by Kalanidhi Maran's Sun TV network for being 'offensive'.

